



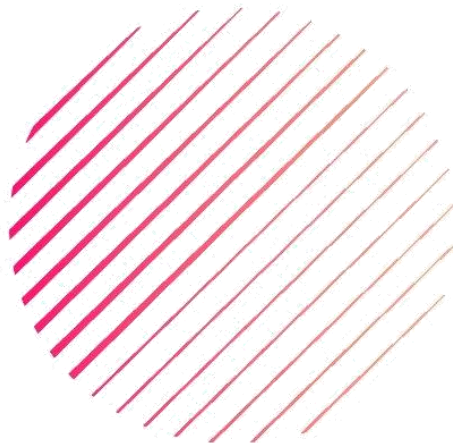
PROJECT REPORT

Feminism & Tech in the ASAL Region

Indigenous Young Women-Led Collective | Northern Kenya ASAL

Implementation Period: 2025

Locations: Turkana, Samburu, and Isiolo Counties



1. Executive Summary

In March 2025, Beyond Borders launched Feminism & Tech in the ASAL Region, a project exploring how feminist principles can reshape technology design, access, and governance in arid and semi-arid lands. The project brought together 28 indigenous young women from Turkana, Samburu, and Isiolo communities to examine how technology intersects with patriarchy, colonial data practices, and pastoralist marginalisation — and to prototype alternatives.

The project produced the ASAL Feminist Tech Principles, a community-authored framework insisting that technology in indigenous contexts must be collective, consent-based, offline-capable, and governed by women. It also trained a cohort of young women to advocate for feminist technology policies at community and county levels, challenging the male-dominated tech spaces that typically exclude pastoralist women.

28	3	1	8
Young women participants	Counties	Feminist tech framework	New feminist tech advocates

2. Background and Rationale

Technology spaces in Kenya — from innovation hubs to policy forums — remain overwhelmingly male, urban, and disconnected from pastoralist realities. In ASAL regions, this gender gap is compounded by nomadic mobility, low formal schooling, and patriarchal control over household resources including phones. Women are frequently the last to access devices, the least consulted about tech projects, and the most vulnerable when data is extracted without consent.

Beyond Borders recognised that “closing the gender digital divide” requires more than handing women smartphones. It requires interrogating whose technology, whose data, and whose control. This project treated feminism not as an add-on to tech training, but as a foundational design ethic — centring care, collective ownership, and the right to refuse.

3. Objectives

- Develop, through participatory process, a set of Feminist Tech Principles appropriate to ASAL indigenous contexts.
- Train indigenous young women to analyse and challenge patriarchal and colonial patterns in existing technology projects.
- Create safe digital and physical spaces for women to experiment with technology without male oversight or judgment.
- Support participants to advocate for feminist technology governance at community and county levels.

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- Document how feminist leadership changes the outcomes of tech adoption in pastoralist settings.

4. Approach and Methods

4.1 Feminist tech labs

Monthly women-only gatherings combined practical skills (audio recording, offline mapping, basic device repair) with feminist analysis of digital colonialism, surveillance, and algorithmic bias. Spaces were deliberately free of male participants to enable open discussion of gendered barriers.

4.2 Principle development

Over six months, participants and elders co-developed the ASAL Feminist Tech Principles through story-sharing, case analysis of failed tech projects, and collective drafting. The principles address: collective consent, offline-first design, sacred knowledge protection, shared-device equity, and women's governance of community data.

4.3 Advocacy training

Participants learned to present the principles to community elders, women's groups, and county officials. Eight women were supported to join or observe county technology and gender forums.

5. Key Results and Outputs

Tangible outputs

- The ASAL Feminist Tech Principles: a 10-point community-authored framework.
- 28 young women trained in feminist technology analysis and practical digital skills.
- Six women-only tech labs established as ongoing safe spaces.
- 12 advocacy presentations to community and county audiences.

Relational and capacity outcomes

- Shift in community discourse: technology is now discussed in women's groups as a site of power and choice, not just consumption.
- Several participants successfully challenged male-dominated community decisions about shared device access.
- Increased confidence among women to refuse tech projects that lack consent protocols.
- Feminist tech lens now applied across all Beyond Borders digital work.

6. Challenges and Lessons Learned

- **Backlash and ridicule.** Some men and external actors dismissed the project as “unnecessary” or “political.” Consistent community grounding and elder support were essential defences.
- **Safety concerns.** Women-only tech spaces required careful location selection to avoid harassment or gossip-based retaliation.
- **Tension between feminist principles and donor timelines.** Participatory principle development is slow. Rushed funding cycles pressure communities to skip consent and governance steps.
- **Intersections of marginalisation.** Stateless women and women from minority clans faced additional barriers even within women’s spaces. Intersectional attention is ongoing.
- **Digital feminism is not urban feminism.** ASAL feminist tech must account for oral culture, collective identity, and mobility — not import frameworks from Nairobi or Silicon Valley.

Key lesson: *Feminist technology in ASAL regions is not about catching women up to existing systems. It is about redesigning systems so that indigenous women’s knowledge, labour, and governance are centred from the start.*

7. Contribution to Beyond Borders’ Work

This project consolidated Beyond Borders’ identity as an indigenous feminist tech collective. The ASAL Feminist Tech Principles now govern all collective digital projects and are used to screen partnerships. The women-only lab model is being replicated, and the advocacy cohort is reshaping how the collective engages with county and national technology policy spaces.

8. Looking Ahead

Beyond Borders will disseminate the Feminist Tech Principles more widely, translate them into additional local languages, and establish a feminist tech fellowship for emerging indigenous women leaders. The collective will also continue building alliances with feminist tech movements globally while insisting that ASAL realities remain central to any shared framework.